MONTHLY UPDATE

Africa: monthly update, August – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-08 · 104 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

Summary of the month

AFRINIC's governance crisis ran on three tracks at once: a third public consultation on the AFRINIC Constitution opened on 25 August under a receivership still undischarged, an Appeal Committee was constituted the same week, and police confirmed investigating a possible forgery in the board election. The AfCFTA's digital-trade layer moved from instrument to build, with a joint venture signed to construct a Digital Trade Corridor and Somalia set to become the 50th ratifying state, while its digital-trade protocol annexes remain unratified two years after adoption. Eight United States senators challenged the terms of Washington's health-data-sharing memorandums with more than 30 African governments, the signed texts still withheld. PAPSS opened a second strategic plan on 4 September aimed at every African country within five years, reporting 30 countries connected and transaction volume up more than 1,000% since 2022 without publishing the volume itself, and stablecoin settlement rails drew their first coordinated regulatory attention from three national supervisors and an exploration by PAPSS itself. Continental venture funding rose to US$4.1bn in 2025, even as the share raised by female-led startups fell to 8.3% and smartphone shipments posted their first year-on-year decline in three years.

Institutions and mandates

Regional collaboration

The AfCFTA's digital layer moved on two fronts. The Secretariat and a Ghanaian technology company signed a joint venture in Accra on 31 August to build a Digital Trade Corridor facilitating, tracking and settling cross-border trade transactions without routing payments through third countries — a signed agreement rather than a system in service, with no build timetable, cost or governance arrangement stated. Separately, 49 of 54 signatories had deposited instruments of ratification as at July 2026, and Somalia is to become the 50th state party on depositing its own in September, having agreed a sequence running from ratification through domesticating the electronic tariff book to a first shipment. Against that momentum, the Protocol on Digital Trade's annexes — approved in February 2025, intellectual-property annexes adopted February 2026 — still await national ratification, and July's eight calls to action to expedite that ratification carry no enforcement mechanism, deadline or named financing.

AFRINIC's governance dispute deepened on every front at once. The board constituted an Appeal Committee on 28 August, effective immediately to 31 December 2026, and called a public policy meeting for Cape Town on 18 November; this sits against an appeal-court order of 15 October 2024 that directed the Official Receiver to complete a board election within two months, a deadline now passed by six months with the receiver still undischarged. Police confirmed to a single publication that they are investigating a possible forgery in the board election, and two other irregularities were reported by a national ISP association rather than adjudicated. The region's absence from internet-number governance was documented from the other side as well: the 2025 IANA Numbering Services Review Committee report lists thirteen of fifteen places, three for every region except AFRINIC, where only a staff member appears and neither community voting seat is filled, and in the same document a 30-day public comment period that drew no comments and an IANA service-level agreement met in full except reverse DNS, at 80%. Both the January and March 2026 meetings established quorum with AFRINIC's community seats still empty, so a valid global decision and an unrepresented region are simultaneously true, and the review's finding that outreach was sufficient does not speak to regional participation. The Union's own social-media announcement is the only account of some of the surrounding governance activity — see Standards, below, for the parallel Constitution consultation.

The African Telecommunications Union completed a leadership transition: its 7th Plenipotentiary Conference elected a secretary general for the next four-year term, seated a 25-state administrative council, passed the chairmanship to Nigeria, adopted a ministerial declaration, and ratified the return of the union's headquarters to Kinshasa on 23 July after the host state paid more than US$1.4m in arrears; no date is stated for the physical move, and the elected secretary general, Zambia's Kezias Kazuba Mwale, takes office on 1 January 2027.

The Association of African Central Banks' 47th Assembly of Governors saw its African Financial Stability Committee's continental portal — carrying its mandate, member banks and working groups — built and launched by the Central Bank of Egypt rather than the Association's own secretariat. The Committee's inaugural African Financial Stability Report, covering 46 countries on December 2024 data, was released in July 2026: its payments chapter, built from 26 central banks' data, finds about 67% of the continent's payment infrastructures are national systems run by central banks, 56% of established systems handle retail, and interoperability of regional and pan-African systems remains limited.

Smart Africa's secretariat issued two calls for expressions of interest on 13 August, closing 31 August — one for content-delivery providers across broadband, data governance, cybersecurity and green-digital domains, one for a consultancy on a gender-inclusion strategy for ICT policymaking — against a membership that has grown from 37 to 42 states under a three-year strategy whose flagships are a data exchange, an innovation platform and digital identity.

Three smaller developments: the Digital Parliaments Project Africa launched at the Parliament of Ghana on 6 August, a cohort of Ghana, Botswana, South Africa, Gambia, Senegal and the Pan-African Parliament with no funder, amount or work programme stated; the eighth Korea-Africa Economic Cooperation ministerial is convened for Seoul, 8-11 September, themed on AI and digital infrastructure, with what it will produce not yet on record; and the 15th Africa Internet Governance Forum is scheduled for Accra, 2-5 November, an event schedule rather than an outcome, with no agenda, host-government commitment or funding yet published.

Instruments and harmonisation

Strategies, plans and policies

The Anti-IFFs Policy Tracker — an eighteen-month pilot in Cote d'Ivoire, Ghana, Liberia, Namibia, Uganda and Zambia built by Tax Justice Network Africa with the AU Commission's ETTIM department — was endorsed for continental roll-out by a joint Ministerial Declaration of the 9th STC on Finance and 5th STC on Trade in Abidjan, 20-24 July as a standing self-assessment instrument scoring anti-IFF policy, legal, institutional and data-sharing frameworks; no roll-out timetable, country list or governance body has been named.

Data protection

An analyst estimate rather than an African Union count puts alignment with the African Union Data Policy Framework at about a third of the 54 member states, with 25 national regulatory sandboxes recorded across 15 countries by late 2024; the Framework carries no stated compliance mechanism, reporting cycle or enforcement route. The continent's data protection authorities marked a date rather than a rule: the Fifth Board of the Network of African Data Protection Authorities signed a declaration on 3 September proclaiming 21 September as Africa Data Protection Day, executing a decision of the network's ninth annual general meeting in May 2026 - an account written by the data protection director of one member authority on a professional network, with the declaration text itself not held.

Standards

AFRINIC's own instruments moved on two separate tracks from its governance dispute above. The Bylaws Review Committee opened a third consultation round on 25 August, closing 30 August, on a draft amended Constitution published 4 August after a first round (20 April, extended to 17 May) and a second (closing 21 August); the Committee has now obtained an independent external legal opinion on a disputed clause and on the board's power to terminate resource membership, which it withholds as privileged, while stating it does not intend to recommend a dispute-resolution clause. The draft's Article 24 on governing law was still blank in the 53-page text members were asked to review provision by provision, carrying only a bracketed note that advice had been sought; other proposed changes would let a two-thirds board vote revoke the nomination committee and restart an election the board itself had judged to have failed, drop the rule barring a conflicted director from voting in favour of a board policy on recusal — relevant because Mauritius company law otherwise lets an interested director vote after disclosure — open a wide advice channel with no register of advice given or received, and create an acting chief-executive office with no maximum term. The published-draft milestone slipped about six weeks against the Committee's own timetable, and no consolidated analysis of any round's submissions is published. A second policy track opened on address exhaustion from the other end. Draft 2 of AFPUB-2026-v6-001 would make any IPv4 request conditional on holding or simultaneously requesting IPv6 space, on a deployment plan showing the network's top-25 IPv4 traffic destinations, and on reaching 25% IPv6 within twelve months, 50% within twenty-four and 75% within forty-eight - 25%, 75% and 95% for content-hosting networks - and the registry's own impact assessment concedes that neither the evidence standard nor the top-25 measurement method is defined. AFRINIC 37 reached no consensus and the proposal returned to the mailing list, the unresolved question being whether the thresholds measure the operator's own work or adoption controlled by its customers and by external networks. A census of the registry's data went the other way: a frozen copy of the official public WHOIS dump held 28,206 maintainer objects, of which 1,345 still carried a deprecated MD5-PW or CRYPT-PW method tag and 1,285 carried nothing else - stored labels rather than credentials or proven vulnerabilities, and the registry publishes no operation-specific account of whether the deployed update service would honour, reject or migrate them. Separately, an objection to the registry's twelve-month IPv4 quarantine floor carried past the Last Call boundary on 26 August rather than being resolved within it — the underlying policy proposal traces to a 2018 case in which an end user was refused an additional /24 for a redundant data centre because aggregate use fell under 90%.

Elsewhere, the Africa PKI Forum's second meeting, held in Abuja, called for harmonised African rules for verifying digital credentials, signatures and documents across borders, with nothing yet adopted and no instrument, timetable or signatory list on file. The African Telecommunications Union's third WRC-27 working group met as an e-meeting from Nairobi, 18-21 August, to prepare recommendations for the third African Preparatory Meeting in Tunis, 7-11 September; the meeting's own output and any proposal text remain unpublished. The telecoms union and the continental standards organisation opened talks with a standardisation partnership on a coordinated continental approach to the standards lifecycle, naming fragmentation as the problem but producing no instrument, work programme or timetable. And the continental standardisation body and a research foundation launched a revised edition of the Good Financial Grant Practice Standard on 27 August.

AI

Funding for the continental AI strategy remains far short of its own ambition: about US$150m of public capital has been committed by African governments against an implementation cost the AU Continental AI Strategy itself prices at US$250bn-US$500bn, on a single analyst's figures reported by one outlet; independent research over the Strategy's first eighteen months found the funding heavily concentrated in Kenya, Nigeria, South Africa and Egypt, with little reaching other member states.

Two research and governance efforts moved: an African Humanitarian AI Citation Index measuring whose knowledge generative-AI answers cite when explaining African humanitarian crises was published on 24 August, and a four-year, EUR 1,873,314 pan-African AI governance research and advocacy project, run by a German university media-research centre with three civil-society organisations, argues for common principles through continental institutions rather than 54 national AI regimes.

Two commercial programmes opened: a technology company offered African students one year of its paid AI assistant tier free from August, with no country list, eligibility rule or statement of what happens after the year; and the same company's Africa Applied AI Lab, based at the Accra AI Community Centre, opened applications on 17 August for a co-development cohort running mid-September to early December, giving selected startups pre-release model access, mentorship and go-to-market support with no equity taken and no cash award guaranteed; cohort size and selection criteria are not stated.

Shared systems and infrastructure

Connectivity

The International Telecommunication Union opened a request for proposals on 3 August, budgeted at US$165,000, for the Phase 1 country-pilots stage of an Africa Digital Connectivity Infrastructure Report, jointly funded with the African Development Bank and the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank; the pilot countries and terms of reference are not established. A separate, already-running project to harmonise national broadband mapping across eleven sub-Saharan regulators (2025-2028) delivered a five-day intermediate GIS training at Lilongwe for practitioners from Malawi, Zimbabwe, Botswana and Zambia, hosted by the Malawian regulator with EU support. Separately, an industry association's modelled figure, cited in a secondary account, puts 416 million Africans as mobile-internet users in 2025, generating US$240bn — 7.8% of continental GDP. The next-generation address base is the measure that has not moved: APNIC Labs figures carried in an AFRINIC policy proposal put IPv6 capability across the region at 6% against a world average of 44%, with eight African countries above 20% and fifteen below 1%, and three million IPv4 addresses recovered under the soft-landing policy since 2020 without a proven rise in IPv6 deployment.

Data Storage

An industry association's own Economic Report puts the time for a data centre to reach 85% occupancy in African markets at six to eight years, against two to three in Europe, and 80-90% of continental data as still processed and stored abroad; neither figure carries a stated method, and the same report projects the African market at US$9.2bn by 2029. Against that, a cloud infrastructure specialist warned that African AI startups concentrated with a single foreign provider carry hidden financial and operational risk, as a new generation of African-founded sovereign and low-latency cloud providers emerges; no continental measure of workload concentration or switching cost is held.

One such provider's AI factory was ranked 36th on the global Top500 supercomputer list, offered as evidence that African organisations can train models on continent-sited infrastructure — a capability ranking rather than a utilisation measure, with no customer count or occupancy figure published.

Energy

An analysis published in August argues that smart-metering and grid-optimisation priorities in the national energy compacts are constrained by a fragmented low-power internet-of-things layer: narrowband coverage reaches only markets such as South Africa, Kenya and Nigeria, and the 2G/3G networks early smart meters depend on are expected to be retired within a meter's ten-to-fifteen-year life. It calls for integrated energy-and-telecom planning and targeted incentives for low-power wide-area rollout. How many compacts have been published is itself unsettled — 29 on this source, 35 from the same author on 11 August, 30 on the financier's own count of 16 June.

Cybersecurity

The African Union Commission's tender for privileged access management on its own networks was amended on 21 August, pushing the bid deadline from 27 August to 10 September and restating the licence requirement at 8 administrator, 40 enterprise privileged-user, 25 business-user and 5 external-vendor subscriptions on three-year terms — a procurement rather than an award, with no budget or supplier published.

Interpol's continental cyberthreat assessment, reaching the base through two secondary accounts, puts reported cybercrime losses at about US$484m — more than double the 2024 figure — across 36 member countries, with AI involved in 55% of surveyed 2025 cases and deepfake incidents up sevenfold between the second and fourth quarters of 2024; against that, only 8% of intelligence analysts are recorded as having advanced AI expertise and 94% of agencies as lacking digital forensics tools. Separately, one vendor's telemetry — its own installed base, not a national or continental measurement — put African organisations at 3,237 attacks a week in July, above the global average of 2,336, with Angola highest of the markets it broke out at 5,714, and recorded the continent's phishing rate as the world's worst at one in 106 emails.

Data Exchange

The AfCFTA's customs-modernisation track produced its largest single figure of the window: a US$3.1bn concession agreement with Bergmans Security Consultants and Supplies Limited to digitise customs across the 50 member states, covering electronic cargo tracking, integrated data centres and risk-management analytics; the concession agreement itself is unpublished, how the twenty-year repayment works and who controls the data in the integrated centres are unstated by either party, and the Secretary-General's figure of about 50 states signed on is uncorroborated.

Smart Africa's Data Exchange (SADX), presented at Conakry in November 2025, was taken into a technical mission on trust chains, interface contracts and incident response with Rwanda, Ghana and Benin; no live exchange is held, but the alliance and a German development agency say a digital identity issued in any of the three is now recognised in the other two, with eighteen further countries said to be joining. The AU's Digital Agriculture Strategy implementation held a continental harmonisation workshop, 11-13 August, seeking interoperable agricultural data platforms and alignment of national and regional systems, against a strategy originally costed at an estimated US$165m continental implementation cost; no member-state implementation count is published. ADAPT, the AfCFTA's own trade-data infrastructure initiative, remains in pilot in Nigeria, Kenya and Morocco on the Secretary-General's own statement, with no live exchange, governing instrument or assessment held.

Three smaller systems moved: IGAD convened a four-day SDMX capacity-building programme with African Development Bank support, aiming at harmonised statistical data structures across its member states; the African Petroleum Producers Organization opened a shared local-content database in Brazzaville on 26 August, described by its owner as the first pan-African platform of its kind; and the African Union Commission's ASRII regional-integration scoring platform trained 20 ECOWAS Commission staff in Abuja, 4-7 August, where the ECOWAS Secretary General said the Commission holds no centralised database of the status of regional legal protocols.

Digital Identity and CRVS

The Africa Programme on Accelerated Improvement of Civil Registration and Vital Statistics (APAI-CRVS) is closing its 2017-2026 decade and opening a 2027-2036 phase, with the African eCRVS Shared Asset named as the intended shared continental standard for cutting fragmented digital procurement across country systems; both accounts reaching the base are secondary to the AU, and no AU statement of the new phase's content, financing or targets is held. Separately, a university research network launched an open-source, retrieval-augmented chatbot comparing identity and data-protection laws across more than 50 African countries on 11 August, intended to help states harmonise their frameworks; no usage figure or governance arrangement is published.

Digital Payments and Fintech

PAPSS closed its first strategic plan and opened a second on 4 September, moving from building spread to deepening use: 30 countries, about 26 central banks and more than 200 financial institutions are connected, with about 38 countries and 80% continental coverage targeted by the end of 2026 and every African country within five years, and phase two is to be built around remittances, merchant payments and a single interface onto connected accounts. The operator says transaction volume has grown more than 1,000% and transaction value 125% since 2022, that payments now settle in an average of seven seconds against an original 120-second design target, and that an artificial-intelligence layer screens for suspicious activity and liens before value is released — but declines to publish the volume and value those percentages are measured from before a report due early 2027, and the same week's briefings put the connected central banks at 24 in one account and 26 in another against the network's own June coverage list of 190 institutions across 28 countries, which also records member states with no live bank or wallet at all. South Africa is named as the only large African market still outside. The obstacles named are not technical: low awareness, national policies mandating settlement in particular currencies, and regional switches' fear of being cannibalised, answered with the formula that a country may keep its own system and connect it in. Two systems modelled on it moved: Barbados and the Bahamas completed proof of concept for a CARICOM Payment and Settlement System explicitly modelled on PAPSS, with Ghana proposing Caribbean access to the AfCFTA on local-currency settlement terms at a Kingston meeting on 2 August; and COMESA's regional clearing house published its digital retail payments scheme rulebook and advertised three platform engineering posts on 24 August, whose duties establish that the platform runs on Mojaloop with an AWS production environment — its technical state inferred from recruitment advertisements rather than stated by the operator, with no transaction volume or go-live date published.

Stablecoins drew their first coordinated regulatory attention: at a UN Economic Commission for Africa webinar on 18 August, market supervisors from Uganda, Ghana and Mauritius set out three national approaches to virtual assets and agreed that supervisory cooperation matters more than identical legislation; the Commission put continental digital-asset users above 54 million, Nigeria alone at about 25.9 million. The continental operator has now joined that question rather than only observing it: PAPSS's chief executive disclosed on 5 September that the system is exploring support for stablecoins and other digital currencies inside the payments system, naming Nigerian securities and central-bank regulation as the approach he endorsed and saying announcements could follow - a statement of intent with no design, timetable or approval attached. A pan-African payments operator's product chief described stablecoins moving from speculative use into remittance and settlement plumbing, citing Mastercard's agreement to acquire BVNK for up to US$1.8bn and Flutterwave's tie-up with Caliza offering USD accounts convertible to USDC and USDT; no African regulator has yet published a settled treatment of stablecoin settlement itself. Separately, a cross-border payments startup launched direct yuan payouts into Chinese bank accounts on 1 September, alongside broader continental take-up of China's Cross-Border Interbank Payment System — known from a single newspaper account, with no operator or central-bank statement of African participation held.

Elsewhere: Standard Bank extended online UnionPay acceptance to nearly 900 merchants across nine markets against a stated 7 million UnionPay cards issued continent-wide; MTN Group's half-year results to 30 June recorded 13.0 billion transactions carrying US$330.5bn, up 17.2% in volume, on 70.8 million monthly active mobile-money users; AfricaNenda's deputy chief executive put the cost of sending money within Africa at 8.78% of the amount sent, against an SDG target of 3%, in an interview rather than a published series — a figure for movement *within* Africa, which is not the one the published series measures: the World Bank's Remittance Prices Worldwide put the cost of sending US$200 into Sub-Saharan Africa at 8.46% in the third quarter of 2025, against a global average of 6.36% and the United Nations target of 3%, with banks close to 15% and much of the cost carried in exchange-rate spreads rather than disclosed fees; a research firm's policy brief put unmet trade finance demand at US$74bn-US$100bn, with commercial banks intermediating about 23% of continental trade against 40% over 2011-2019; and instant-payment interoperability was described as meeting a regulatory wall of divergent national rules.

Sectoral management information systems

Three health-data systems moved. The Economic Commission for Africa's five-year African Initiative on Transforming Health Financing (2026-2030), launched in Tangier in April, carries a digital component — a shared data and intelligence platform the Commission's chief of staff called a "digital twin of the health budget" — alongside six other outcomes; the Commission puts fewer than a third of health systems in low-income settings as able to track spending digitally in real time, and 30-40% of health spending as lost to inefficiency, but no platform, procurement or delivery date is published for the digital component itself. WHO launched a Regional Health Data Hub from Addis Ababa on 27 August, integrating fragmented health data across all 47 member states of the region, bringing together maternal, newborn, child and adolescent health and noncommunicable disease data; the platform carries 53 datasets and 7,965 indicators, about 65% of them ingested against a target of 80% by the end of 2026, and its governance framework is still in development — the organisation's own figures, with no independent measure of coverage held.

The African Union's ASRII platform for regional-integration scoring — see Data Exchange, above, for its ECOWAS training — replaces manual data collection across political, economic, infrastructure and social pillars, developed with the regional economic communities, the Economic Commission for Africa and the African Development Bank; no published score or coverage list is yet held.

The seam these platforms are meant to close is the one a live outbreak found again. The African Society for Laboratory Medicine's own multi-country assessment, completed before the Democratic Republic of Congo's current Ebola outbreak, covered 26 countries — every one with a functioning surveillance system and core diagnostic capacity, nearly nine in ten with a laboratory coordination unit, and 3,964 laboratories mapped across fourteen, and named digital interoperability between laboratories and surveillance platforms, alongside specimen referral, workforce surge and domestic financing, as the weak points; the response has had to improvise at exactly those seams. It is a reference study written up by its own author rather than a dated development, and is carried here as the measure a data hub would have to move.

Coordination and collaboration

ICT Industry

A dominant messenger platform announced that free service messages to businesses will end from 1 October, with businesses charged per delivered message at rates varying by country and message type — a pricing decision by a foreign operator, outside any African regulator's reach on the record held, with per-country rates unpublished.

Innovation ecosystem

A foundation-funded incubation programme opened applications for a second continental cohort of technology startups, with no cohort size, selection criterion or first-cohort result published. A European development agency opened a EUR120,000 procurement for a multi-country mapping of African entrepreneurship- and innovation-support organisations, bids due 17 August, under a Europe-Africa digital innovation programme; no supplier or country list is stated.

US / hyperscaler activities

The United States' America First Global Health Strategy data-sharing programme drew its first congressional pushback. Under a model Data Sharing Agreement — held only as a blank template dated 11 March, its own text not published — memorandums worth US$20bn have been signed with more than 30 countries since December 2025, giving the United States at-will access to seven classes of a partner's national health system for 25 years with a 10-year post-termination tail, and committing signatories to load 90% of clinical encounters into electronic medical records within two years and to supply pathogen specimens and genetic sequence data within five days of detection; section 4.7 makes failure on those commitments grounds for changing or discontinuing assistance. Ghana refused the memorandum in April, Zimbabwe withdrew in February and Zambia shelved in May; Kenya's framework is before the Court of Appeal, with a ruling due by the end of October. The signed texts themselves remain withheld — the State Department published a subset in March 2026 and then removed public access, and a freedom-of-information suit covering sixteen African countries, *Public Citizen v. Department of State* (No. 1:26-cv-01137, D.D.C.), was unresolved when filed on 2 April. A rights organisation's clause-by-clause assessment of the seven signed memorandums it holds — Ethiopia, Kenya, Mozambique, Nigeria, Rwanda, Liberia and Uganda — found the model's terms not applied uniformly: all seven require broad audit access, three (Liberia, Mozambique, Rwanda) commit to supplying any requested audit data with no stated privacy safeguard, two (Liberia, Nigeria) defer the data-sharing arrangement to an unpublished appendix, and the pathogen-sequencing clause appears in five of the seven. In the week to 19 August, eight United States senators wrote to the Secretary of State challenging the demands for direct access to partner governments' health-data systems as unprecedented and at odds with US policy on the data of American citizens, requesting a briefing and a written answer by the end of August.

China activities

China's engagement with the continental telecoms body deepened around a memorandum whose own text is not held. The African Telecommunications Union names a 2025 memorandum with the China Academy of Information and Communications Technology as the foundation for its Secretary-General's participation in an Advanced Seminar on African Digital Development, which opened in Hangzhou on 24 August; the memorandum is known only from the union's own social-media account, with no signing date, term or work programme held. Four days later, the China-Africa Digital Technology Cooperation Center was formally inaugurated at Hangzhou on 28 August as a standing platform for market-entry services, industry matchmaking and training, drawing officials from 18 African countries and the ATU, UNDP, UNICEF and Smart Africa; a same-day matchmaking session produced cooperation intentions in digital infrastructure, AI, cybersecurity and digital skills. This is one centre against an announcement that had promised application-cooperation centres with the African Union and 5,000 training places over five years; no budget, term or figure for the matchmaking intentions is published, and no African Union instrument establishing the centre is held.

India activities

India enters this record for the first time, and as a conversation rather than a commitment. Its external affairs ministry received an official delegation from Ethiopia, Sierra Leone, Malawi, Zambia, Rwanda and the African Union Commission on using digital public infrastructure to promote development, improve governance, widen inclusion and strengthen the delivery of citizen services, on a visit coordinated by the United Nations Development Programme's India office. No agreement, financing, technology transfer or follow-on process is named, so what the base holds is the fact of the meeting and the six states that sent people to it.

Capacity and inclusion

Training and skills

A five-year, foundation-funded digital-skills initiative, AYCE Digital, launched on 27 August run by a United States university through more than 100 local facilitators, targeting foundational digital literacy for more than 50,000 learners, intermediate workforce credentials for 10,000 and advanced technical certifications in AI, cloud computing and project management for 2,500; no financial value is stated and no cohort, completion or placement figure is yet on file.

The month's other capacity item is about who runs the state rather than who uses the technology. A continental capacity foundation convened alumni of its public-sector leadership programme, run with private-foundation support, and argued that reform stalls on leadership gaps, institutional fragmentation and resistance to change rather than on policy — its executive secretary putting it that public sector reform is rarely held back by a lack of good ideas. No cohort size, cost, country list or evaluation is published.

Digital divides

Smartphone affordability worsened on a research house's own tracking: shipments fell 7% year on year in the second quarter of 2026 — the first decline in three years, the sub-$100 segment down 34% (nearly three million units) and the average selling price up US$41 to US$202, with memory now nearly 60% of the bill of materials for sub-$400 devices; an entry-level handset can cost up to 73% of a low-income adult's monthly income in sub-Saharan Africa, and the tracker forecasts a 26% decline for the year overall. Country performance diverged sharply within the quarter — South Africa up 17%, Nigeria down 11%, Kenya down 15%, Egypt down 26%. Separately, an industry-body accelerator backed by two private foundations opened its next call for digital-inclusion solutions for women and girls across India and sub-Saharan Africa, applications due 17 August, at a grant amount covering both regions with no African allocation stated.

Finance

MoUs and other agreements

Afreximbank's corporate academy and CreditRegistry signed a three-year memorandum from Cairo on 25 August integrating the latter's credit-education curriculum into digital financial-literacy training, and undertaking to drive awareness of the bank's MANSA due-diligence repository and of PAPSS; a first initiative targets 20,000-30,000 learners against a stated ambition of reaching about three million families and businesses, with no budget or delivery schedule published. A five-year memorandum between an Indian technology company, a continental investment council and an Ivorian mobile operator, dated 7 August and fully executed 19 August per a regulatory filing, covers national fibre backbones, 4G/5G, submarine cable landing, digital identity and digital-payment platforms across the continent, with no financial commitment disclosed and no country programme yet named.

New investments

Development finance moved the largest sums. The Africa Finance Corporation raised CHF 350m on a five-year digital bond on 13 August — the first such issuance by an African institution, priced at 1.4925% and its fourth and largest Swiss-franc issuance. Africa50's Infrastructure Acceleration Fund reached a fourth close of about US$330m on 10 August, joined by British International Investment's US$20m alongside the African Development Bank and the IFC — capital directed across logistics, power, water and digital connectivity rather than a digital-only vehicle. A French development agency's own sectoral review put its African digital portfolio at EUR 558m, 59% of its global digital book of about EUR 948m, against EUR 293m newly committed group-wide in 2025 — the portfolio figure Africa-specific, the new-commitment figure group-wide.

Venture and private capital moved unevenly. African tech equity and debt funding reached US$4.1bn in 2025, up about 25% year on year across 570 deals, with debt at its highest-ever volume of US$1.6bn (up 63%) making up almost half of total capital raised — growth that came through larger ticket sizes rather than more transactions, with pre-seed and seed pressure and the path to liquidity both flagged as unaddressed. Limited-partner commitments to African private-capital funds fell to US$272m of disclosed value in the second quarter of 2026, against US$847m a year earlier and US$1.18bn in the first quarter, even as deal count rose to 64 from 53 and information technology's share of commitments rose to 61% from 17% — disclosed value covering only commitments whose size was published, so the fall in value and the rise in count are not measured on the same base. Against that, mergers and acquisitions in the digital economy reached 84 deals worth an estimated US$11.4bn in disclosed value to 17 August, already past all of 2025's 68 deals, led by financial services on 27 deals and concentrated in South Africa, Nigeria and Egypt, with MTN Group's proposed US$6.2bn purchase of 75% of IHS Towers the largest single value. The share of funded ventures led by a female chief executive fell to 5 of 60 (8.3%), taking 2.8% of capital, against 17 of 178 (9.6%, 7.9% of capital) in 2025 — the lowest point in a series running 11.7% (2021), 10.9% (2022), 15.3% (2023) and 12.5% (2024).

Individual raises and closes: IFC took US$25m of equity inside a wider US$50m raise by Jumia on 12 August, against the investor's own projections — untested and undated — of about 60,000 annual active sellers and 1,800 direct jobs; a continental infrastructure financier and a Saudi investment company signed a combined US$300m investment in carrier-neutral platform WIOCC on 1 September, its largest capital raise to date; and a private-capital fund put US$12m into a pan-African messaging-infrastructure provider carrying one-time passwords and transaction alerts across 35 countries through 15 operator partnerships. A Swiss blockchain operator said on 25 August it will discontinue its chain on 31 October and wind down its governance organisation, ending a funding and accelerator pipeline that had backed African companies in Nigeria, South Africa and Rwanda, citing insufficient chain revenue; African blockchain startups raised US$90.1m in 2025, down 26.6% on the year.

Grant and programme funding: a foundation opened a call for AI-driven digital contraception-information proposals across sub-Saharan Africa, up to US$500,000 a project, closing 25 August; LINGUA Africa selected 26 language-model projects covering more than 50 African languages and sign languages across 47 countries, each eligible for up to US$250,000 cash and US$400,000 in compute credits, jointly funded by a foundation, two US technology companies and an African research collective with no single total disclosed; KOICA's Youth Leadership Programme, US$34m stated by Korea, ran in Accra 2-29 August for 200 participants from five countries on AI-driven digital government, with no split by country or component; and a technology company's African accelerators state more than US$1bn raised cumulatively by their startups since 2017, with a survival rate above 90% against a 70-80%

failure rate stated for African startups generally — the company's own figures, with no cohort list or methodology published. Separately, a UN development agency told its executive board that its finance model is shifting from delivering aid to using scarce public resources to draw in private investment, citing official development assistance down 23.3% in 2025 with a further fall expected — a stated direction rather than an instrument, bearing on every donor-funded digital programme this base holds without naming any of them. A British development finance institution and Africa50 announced a strengthened partnership to scale infrastructure financing including connectivity, with no commitment amount, vehicle or timetable published, and an outlet's analysis of fourteen of the same institution's investments found 79% at Series B or later, reading as a later-stage investor rather than a venture fund.

A women's finance programme was launched on a mobile-money rail rather than a bank one. A continental development bank and a telecommunications group launched a digital finance programme for more than 34,000 women-led enterprises in five African countries, running through the group's Mixx and Mvola platforms and combining digital lending, financial literacy training and business development services, under the bank's women's finance initiative and a multilateral facility. The money was committed a year and a half earlier and inside a much larger facility: the bank approved a US$160m senior corporate loan to the group on 31 January 2025 for 4G and 5G network expansion across nine countries, earmarking over US$10m for 22,000 women entrepreneurs in Madagascar through the Mvola platform and a US$2.5m grant for financial literacy and credit access for 34,000 women-led businesses in Madagascar, Tanzania and Senegal, so the September announcement is the launch of an earmarked component rather than new capital. No tenor or disbursement schedule is published for either; the announcement puts the financing gap facing women-owned businesses on the continent at about US$49bn.

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